

Romania



A large Balkan country, divided by the Carpathian mountains, with a latinate culture and language.

106 CE The Roman emperor Trajan conquers the area now forming Romania, and establishes the province of Dacia. Roman rule lasts until 272. The Latin-derived language and the country's name are hallmarks of lasting Roman influence.

600s Invasions first of Slavs and later of Magyars, who occupy and settle in Transylvania.

1000s Hungary conquers Transylvania. In the 13th and 14th centuries, separate Romanian principalities emerge in Wallachia and Moldavia but are then conquered by the Turks: Wallachia pays tribute to the Ottoman Empire from 1417, Moldavia from 1456, and Transylvania from 1526.

1699 The Habsburgs win control of Transylvania under the Treaty of Karlowitz. Wallachia and Moldavia, however, remain vassals of the Turks.

1828–34 Moldavia and Wallachia occupied by Russia.

1848 Demands for independence from the various Romanian provinces are swiftly crushed by the Ottoman imperial authorities.

1858 The Paris Convention, after the Crimean War, recognizes Wallachian and Moldavian independence within the Ottoman Empire, as the notion of Romanian unity and independence gains strength.

1859 Unification of Moldova and Wallachia forms the basis of a future Romania.

1877–78 At the end of the Russo-Turkish War, Romania gains its independence, with the reigning prince, Charles of Hohenzollern-Sigmaringen, ruling as King Carol I from 1881–1914.

1883 Romania is closely identified with the Triple Alliance of Germany, Austria-Hungary, and Italy. Its royal dynasty is a branch of the German imperial family.

1913 Gains southern Dobruja region from Bulgaria at the end of the Second Balkan War.

1914–27 Ferdinand I is king.

1914 At the outbreak of World War I, Romania remains neutral despite close ties with Germany, but is courted by the Allies who offer the territory of Transylvania as an inducement.

1916–18 Enters World War I on Allied side, but is quickly invaded and occupied by Austrian and Bulgarian troops. By the end of the war, Romania has lost

335,700 men, or 44 percent of all its soldiers, with another 120,000, or 16 percent, injured.

1918 Gains Bessarabia from Russia after Moldavians appeal to Romania for help against the Bolsheviks.

1920 Treaty of Trianon—the post-war peace treaty with Hungary—transfers Transylvania to Romania, which thus gains a sizeable Hungarian minority population.

1924 Communists banned in unstable political arena.

1927 On the death of Ferdinand II, his heir, Carol, is in France, having been disinherited in 1925. Carol's six-year-old son takes the throne under a regency.

1930 Carol returns to claim his throne as Carol II.

1938 Carol II establishes royal autocracy.

1940 Territory forcibly ceded to the USSR, Bulgaria, and Hungary after pressure from USSR and Germany. Coup by fascist Iron Guard as King Carol abdicates in favor of son, Michael. Ion Antonescu comes to power.

1940 Signs Tripartite Pact with Germany and in 1941 enters World War II on Axis side, hoping to recover Bessarabia.

1944 Romania switches sides as Soviet troops reach border.

1945 Soviet-backed regime installed: the Romanian Communist Party plays an increasing role.

1946 Romania regains Transylvania from Hungary and Dobruja from Bulgaria, but not Bessarabia. Communist-led National Democratic Front wins majority in disputed elections.

1947 King Michael is forced to abdicate as Romania becomes a communist republic.

1948–53 Centrally planned economy is put in place.

1953 Leaders of Jewish community are prosecuted for Zionism.

1955 Joins Warsaw Pact.

1958 Soviet troops withdraw.

1964 Prime Minister Gheorghiu-Dej declares national sovereignty; he proposes joint planning by all communist countries to lessen Soviet economic control.

1965 Nicolae Ceausescu becomes party secretary after death of Gheorghiu-Dej.

1968–80 Ceausescu condemns Soviet invasion of Czechoslovakia, and pursues an increasingly independent foreign policy.

1989 Demonstrations against communist rule lead to savage crackdown with many killed. The armed forces join with opposition in National Salvation Front (NSF) to form a government: Ion Iliescu is declared president. Ceausescu and his wife are summarily tried and shot.

1990 NSF wins election: political prisoners are freed but many are later reinterned.

1991 New constitution, providing for market reform, is approved.

1994 General strike demands faster economic reform.

1996 Reconciliation treaty with Hungary.

1996 Center-right coalition wins elections as Iliescu is defeated.

1997 Treaty recognizes Ukraine's sovereignty over territory ruled by Romania in 1919–40.

2000 Ion Iliescu wins elections as the center parties collapse; the nationalist Greater Romania Party is second.

2004 Romania joins NATO.

2007 Romania joins the EU.

2008 EU warns Romania over its high level of corruption and threatens to withhold economic subsidies.

2010 Romanian government agrees to host US missile shield.

◀◀448–49 Raising the Iron Curtain

Moldova



Formerly part of Romania and then the USSR, Moldova has decided to remain independent.

100s CE The territory forms part of the kingdom of Dacia.

500s Slavs migrate to the area.

1300s Dragos becomes the first prince of Moldavia, having migrated with his followers from the northern Carpathians. In 1349 first independent Moldavian state emerges, but is soon a subject of Poland.

1457–1504 Stephen the Great defeats a Turkish army at Rahova, but in 1484 his army is defeated and by 1514 Stephen's son Bogdan III pays tribute to Turkey. By the end of the 16th century, Bessarabia (Eastern Moldavia) is under Turkish control; Western Moldavia eventually becomes part of Romania.

1812 Russia annexes Bessarabia. Many Moldavians flee west, fearing the introduction of serfdom.

1917 After the Bolshevik revolution, a national council declares Bessarabia an autonomous republic of the Federation of Russian Socialist Republics.

1918 Romanian troops drive out the Russians and Bessarabia joins Romania.

1924 A Moldavian ASSR is established within the Ukrainian SSR by the USSR.

1940 Romania cedes Bessarabia to the USSR as part of the Nazi-Soviet Pact.

1941–44 Bessarabia again under Romanian control.

1944 Returns to Soviet control.

1990 Declares sovereignty as USSR collapses. Transnistria (on eastern bank of the Dniester) also declares sovereignty.

1989 Romanian is reinstated as the official language.

1991 Independence as Moldova. Gagauzia in the south declares independence, but accepts autonomy in 1994.

1993 Pro-unification parties' general election defeat leads to the rejection in a 1994 referendum of reunification with Romania.

2001 Transnistrian authorities halt the withdrawal of Russian forces.

2006 Transnistria referendum backs independence from Moldova.

2009 Protests lead to new elections after victory of ruling Communist party. In the revote a right-wing coalition is victorious, but in 2010 the Constitutional Court dissolves parliament and orders fresh elections to be held.

COMMUNIST DICTATOR (1918–89)

NICOLAE CEAUSESCU

Nicolae Ceausescu was the independent-minded communist leader of Romania from 1965 onward. He stressed the sovereignty of his country against the USSR, although he kept Romania in both the Warsaw Pact and Comecon. His obsession with paying off the national debt impoverished the country, and his cult of personality, repression of minorities, and grandiose public works programs made him deeply unpopular. When Romania turned against the communists in 1989, he and his hated wife were summarily tried and executed on Christmas Day.

